

downsides of having more than one anti-virus tool on his computer, the product itself does its best to ensure the stability of the system. But then, think about it again – you have two anti-virus products installed on the system and you can use only one! That's how it should be but it doesn't fulfill your temporary need to install two anti-virus products at once!

We ask you – what's easier – installing a virtual machine and using it to run another anti-virus tool or installing two anti-virus tools on your computer and risking your OS installation? you're probably convinced at this stage of the usefulness of virtual machines for this purpose.

Virtual machines can also be used to do “secure browsing”. With NAT featured by most virtualization software, you can access your host operating system's internet connection in the guest and use it for browsing the internet. In case you get a viral infection from the internet (because of a download or because you visited a malicious web site), it's just your “virtual” machine getting effected; reinstall it, or revert back to an older snapshot. This way you make sure that your host OS is not at any risk! Also, your browsing history, bookmarks and cookies and all such browsing activities is well protected with the guest operating system's authentication methods and if you still feel insecure, you can use encryption inside the virtual machine or encrypt the virtual machine itself (e.g. using the VMware Workstation's encryption feature). Yes, the virtual machine will take time to boot up and there's a little bit of an extra overhead but it's a perfect way to stay secure if you have something to lose.

Portability of an environment

At times when you need to set up an environment on more than one PC, virtualization is bliss. Someone might say that “hard disk cloning” is another solution. Yes, “hard disk cloning” indeed is a solution but when the hardware differs, it may not give you results you wanted. Think of a time when your friend asks you to set up a complex application development environment (LAMP is one of those environments), just the way you have it on your computer. There are a few things you can do:

- ▶ You can ask him to come to your home with a laptop and try to install it on his machine.
- ▶ You can go to his home to help him install the software.
- ▶ You can help him over the phone / email or chat, even remote control. But think about this:
- ▶ What if your friend doesn't have an internet connection?

